

Why Startups Fail : The Architect of Silence A Complete Story of Leadership, Ego, and the Cost of Forgetting Humanity

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Editing Why Startups Fail : The Architect of Silence A...

Summarise this blog

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Photo by the blowup on Unsplash

Disclaimer

This story is a work of reflective non-fiction based on real experiences, conversations, and observations spanning several months of interaction. The characters and platform names have been fictionalized to protect identities and maintain confidentiality while preserving the truth of the events and the lessons they carry. All dialogues and situations have been reconstructed from memory to reflect the essence of what was said and felt across multiple conversations—public and private. The intent is not to attack, humiliate, or defame any individual or organization, but to document a leadership learning journey for the benefit of leaders, community managers, patients, and anyone who has ever felt silenced. Names, roles, and specific details have been altered or generalized to ensure that the focus remains on the broader leadership lessons rather than personal grievances. The views expressed are personal reflections and do not represent any organization.

If you see yourself in this story—as a leader, a creator, a patient, or a human being—ask yourself: what kind of leader do you want to be?

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Podcast



The Architect of Silence

Jul 18 • The Curious Leader

Preview

Characters

Character	Role	Description
Arjun	Creator, Researcher, Contributor	A highly sensitive, neurodivergent creator who believes in empathy, curiosity, and doing the right thing even when no one is watching. He has CAS (Childhood Apraxia of Speech)—a condition Meera already knows about. He is a solo breadwinner, unemployed, trying to save his career. He also has CFS (Chronic Fatigue Syndrome), which means every hour he spends is a sacrifice. He is an HSP (Highly Sensitive Person), processing everything deeper and carrying more. He has given hours of strategic research, engaged with the technical team, and contributed insights worth thousands of dollars. He learned his boundaries the hard way, but still gave his research for free—not because he expected representation, but because the platform was tied to an NGO, and he believed in the mission. He wrote directly to leadership because the community manager was young and didn't understand the necessity of the questions he was asking.
Meera	VP, Founder, Leader	A successful leader who built a creator platform from the ground up. She is driven, protective of her company, and has a low tolerance for criticism—real or perceived. She believes in growth, metrics, and protecting her intellectual property. She is fully aware of Arjun's CAS and CFS, and the fact that her AI-assisted work sounds good to human ears. She has built a platform that attracts creators but has no talent program and no clear value proposition for audiences. She speaks in polished corporate language that impresses the naive but masks her cruelty.
Aranya	Community Manager (Gen Z)	Young, idealistic, and still learning. She is the community manager who was doing her best but lacked the experience to fully understand the depth of Arjun's questions. She did not escalate—Arjun wrote to leadership directly. She represents the many young professionals who are thrust into complex situations without the tools or authority to handle them.
The Technical Team	Engineers, Product Team	The team Arjun engaged with, providing detailed feedback on architecture, user experience, and product roadmap.
The Architect	Technology Lead	A silent character who knows Arjun's work and attitude as a creator but stays silent—not out of malice, but out of powerlessness. He cannot speak because he does not have the authority to represent the organization externally. He represents the many bystanders in corporate structures who witness injustice but are silenced by hierarchy.
The NGO Leaders	Reference Point	The ones who listened, acknowledged, and gave Arjun access and ethics. They are the contrast to Meera's leadership. They gave him a user ID, access to grassroots communities, and ethics to reply when he asked. They read his suggestions on keeping girl children in school—before Ar was born.

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Prologue: The Uncredentialed Learner



Photo by Tim Mossholder on Unsplash

Arjun had never held a leadership title. He had never managed a team. He had never earned an MBA. He was just a creator who asked questions.

But he learned what leadership actually meant.

Not from a textbook. Not from a classroom. Not from a boss.

From experience. From failure. From the silence that followed his questions.

He had CAS—a condition that made every word he spoke take effort. Every sentence required concentration. Yet he had built a career by creating, by contributing, by caring.

He had CFS—Chronic Fatigue Syndrome. Every hour he spent was a sacrifice. Every effort he made was effort he couldn't afford to lose.

He was a Highly Sensitive Person (HSP), which meant he processed everything deeper—he felt more, noticed more, and carried more than most people.

He was a solo breadwinner, unemployed, trying to save his career. He had hope. He had trust. He had a belief that if he worked hard enough, if he contributed enough, if he cared enough—someone would notice. Someone would value him. Someone would help him when he needed it.

He was wrong.

But even when he learned he was wrong, he still gave.

Part One: The Hope



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The Platform That Promised Community



Photo by John Cameron on Unsplash

Arjun joined VoxSphere with hope. It was supposed to be a place where creators could share their work, build an audience, and earn money.

It was supposed to be a community.

He didn't have a degree in psychology or marketing. But he was curious. He observed. He researched. And he found himself asking questions.

Questions that the platform's leaders didn't want to hear.

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The Questions That Got Him Silenced



Photo by Towfiqu barbhuiya on Unsplash

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Over several months, Arjun asked questions—genuine questions, the kind any product leader should be able to answer.

His Question	The Response
"Where is the listener program?"	Dismissed
"Why would I choose this over YouTube?"	Ignored
"Why is the pay declining?"	Humiliated
"Why are creators expected to bring their own audience?"	Silenced
"What's the advantage over YouTube?"	Attacked
"Why are the rules constantly changing?"	No response
"Why is the experience so difficult to navigate?"	Dismissed

These were not attacks. These were questions from someone who cared about the platform.

They were treated as threats.

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The Dysfunctional Pattern



Photo by Omar Flores on Unsplash

Arjun recognized the pattern. He had seen it before—in his own dysfunctional family, in broken organizations, in failing platforms.

What He Did	What Happened
Asked honest questions	Was dismissed
Offered solutions	Was ignored
Spoke truth	Was humiliated
Showed vulnerability	Was targeted
Gave feedback	Was silenced

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This was not a community. This was a system designed to extract, not to grow.

In his family, he had been the scapegoat—the one cornered, blamed, and never appreciated no matter what he did. He saw the same pattern here. It was easy to whine and point the finger. It was easy to blame. But no one ever asked if he was okay. No one ever checked on him. Even a pet comes and licks a person to check if they are fine—but here, he was nothing more than an ATM. A resource. A tool.

And he had learned the hard way that you can't fix people who don't want to be fixed.

Part Two: The Direct Appeal



Photo by Vitaly Gariev on Unsplash

The Young Community Manager

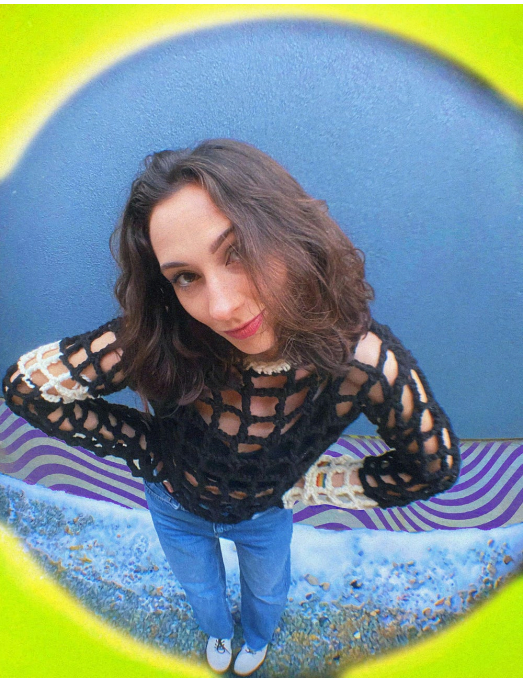


Photo by Isi Parente on Unsplash

Ananya was the community manager at VoxSphere. She was young, idealistic, and eager to learn. She genuinely wanted to do a good job. But she lacked experience. She lacked depth. She lacked the ability to fully understand the strategic questions Arjun was asking.

Arjun didn't go through Ananya. He didn't expect her to handle his questions. He understood that she was young, that she was still learning, that some questions were too big for her level.

He wrote directly to leadership.

What Arjun Did	What He Didn't Do
Wrote directly to leadership	Escalate through Ananya
Asked strategic questions	Ask Ananya to solve them
Sought clarity on product direction	Expect Ananya to know the answers
Engaged with leadership	Blame Ananya for the situation

“Arjun didn't escalate Anunya. Arjun wrote an email to the leadership asking these questions—not because Ananya was not doing her job. She is young; she may not understand the necessity of those questions.”

This was the reality.

Arjun recognized Ananya's limitations. He didn't blame her. He didn't expect her to handle what she couldn't understand.

He went straight to the people who should have been able to answer. As he beleived he was a Partner as they said.

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The Email to Leadership



Photo by Markus Spiske on Unsplash

Arjun's Email to Leadership:

“Dear Meera and Team,

I've been a creator on VoxSphere for several months now. I've contributed research, feedback, and strategic analysis. I've engaged with the technical team on architecture and user experience. Your team is doing great job in building the community and glad to see feature X been implemented it helps a lot for the creators.

I'm writing because I have some questions about the platform's direction:

- 1. Where is the listener program? Without listeners, creators can't build sustainable audiences.*
- 2. Why would a creator choose VoxSphere over YouTube? What's our unique value proposition?*

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3. Why is the pay declining while expectations for creators are rising?
4. Why are creators expected to bring their own audiences? Isn't that the platform's job?
5. Why are the rules constantly changing without warning?
6. Why is the UI experience so difficult to navigate?

I'm not asking these questions to attack. I'm asking because I care about the platform. I believe in what we could become. But I'm struggling to see a future where this works for creators.

I would appreciate your perspective.

*Regards,
Arjun”*

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Meera’s Response



Photo by Hunters Race on Unsplash

Meera read the email. She knew Arjun's questions were valid. She knew they exposed gaps in the platform's strategy. She knew she didn't have good answers.

And she was angry.

What She Felt	What She Did
Threatened	Attacked the messenger
Exposed	Silenced the questioner
Defensive	Humiliated the creator
Ego-bruised	Dismissed the contribution

She didn't respond to the questions. She responded to the person asking them.

“To the community manager, why is your community creator escalating to me? I'll take care from here.”

This was the dismissal. Ananya was young—she may not have understood the necessity of the questions. But Meera did. And she chose to silence rather than answer.

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Ananya’s Position



Photo by Headway on Unsplash

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Ananya watched as Meera stepped in. She was relieved—finally, leadership was handling it. She didn’t know what Meera would say or do. She trusted that the VP would handle it professionally.

She didn’t realize she was being used as a shield.

What Ananya Thought	What Was Actually Happening
"Leadership is stepping in"	"Leadership is silencing a creator"
"The problem is being solved"	"The problem is being buried"
"I did the right thing"	"I'm being used"

Ananya had no idea.

She was young. She was learning. She genuinely believed in the platform and its leadership.

She didn’t see the cruelty because she didn’t know to look for it.

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Part Three: The Humiliation



Photo by Stanisław Krawczyk on Unsplash

The Private 1-on-1 Call



Photo by Taylor Grote on Unsplash

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Meera scheduled a private 1-on-1 call with Arjun.

No community manager present. No witnesses. No record.

The call was never about listening. It was about silencing.

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The Disability Attack (On the 1-on-1 Call)

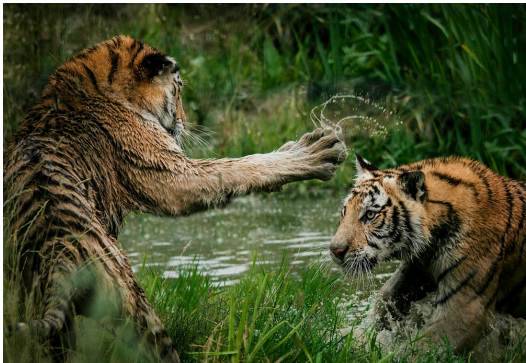


Photo by Frida Lannerström on Unsplash

Meera to Arjun (during the private call):

“Your content lacks a hook. It’s monotone. It sounds like it’s AI-generated.”

Full Picture:

Meera already knew Arjun had CAS. She already knew his work was AI-assisted. She already knew his content sounded good to human ears. She already knew he had CFS and was fighting every day to contribute.

This was not feedback. This was a targeted attack—delivered privately, deliberately, and without witnesses.

What She Did	What It Reveals
Called his voice “monotone”	Weaponized his disability
Said it sounds “AI-generated”	Weaponized his transparency
Ignored that his content was good to human ears	Denied the reality of his effort
Did it in a private call	Ensured no one would witness her cruelty

What she could have said: *“I appreciate your effort. Let me give you some constructive feedback on how to make your content more engaging.”*

Instead, she used what she knew against him—privately, deliberately, and without accountability.

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The Humiliation (On the 1-on-1 Call)



Photo by Ava Sol on Unsplash

Meera to Arjun (during the private call, when he asked for a reference or recommendation):

"Do I know you? Have you worked for me? I don't give fake recommendations."

Full Picture:

Arjun didn't ask for a job. He didn't ask for money. He asked for a reference—a simple acknowledgment that his work mattered. LinkedIn has a feature: *"We worked together on different projects."*

He was a solo breadwinner. He was unemployed. He was dealing with CAS and CFS. He was trying to save his career. He was hoping the trust he earned in good days would help him in bad days.

What she could have said: *"I appreciate your contributions. I can't give a reference for work you did as a creator, but I can acknowledge your effort. Here's a simple note you can use."*

Instead, she said: *"Do I know you? Have you worked for me?"*

This wasn't just a no. It was a dismissal of his existence. A denial of his contribution. A rejection of his humanity—delivered in a private call where no one could witness her cruelty.

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The “We Are Not an NGO” Defense (On the 1-on-1 Call)



Photo by Patrick Tomasso on Unsplash

Meera to Arjun (during the private call, when he suggested they learn from the NGO model):

“We are not an NGO. We are a business. We have to protect our intellectual property.”

Full Picture:

Arjun had worked with NGOs before—not as a volunteer, but as a feedback giver. They gave him a user ID, access to grassroots communities, ethics to reply when he asked, and recognition of his ideas. They did this because they believed in the mission.

What she could have said: *“I appreciate the suggestion. We are a business, but we can learn from the NGO model of listening and acknowledging contributors.”*

Instead, she said: *“We are not an NGO.”*

This was the shield. The defense. The excuse to not listen, not acknowledge, not give—delivered privately, personally, and without witnesses.

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The “Nothing Special” Dismissal (On the 1-on-1 Call)

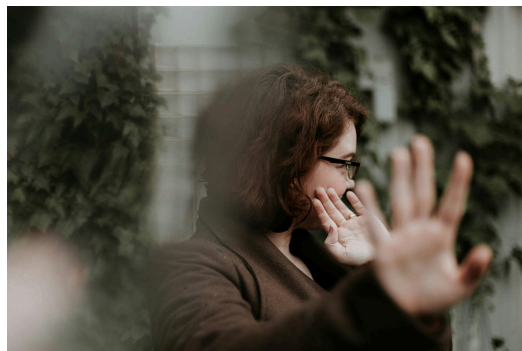


Photo by Priscilla Du Preez CA on Unsplash

Meera to Arjun (during the private call, when he asked about his contributions):

“Your ideas are just as other users provide. It goes as sprint backlog. Nothing special.”

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Full Picture:

Arjun had given hours of strategic thinking. He had analyzed platform failures—Koo, Byju's, PicSee. He had developed frameworks for listener acquisition. He had researched retention strategies. He had engaged with the technical team, providing detailed feedback on architecture, user experience, and product roadmap. He had done all of this with empathy and curiosity—all while battling CFS and unemployment.

What she could have said: *"I appreciate your contributions. Let me see how we can incorporate some of your ideas."*

Instead, she said: *"Nothing special."*

This wasn't just dismissive. It was an erasure of his effort. A denial of his value. A rejection of his existence—delivered in a private call where no one would hear it and no one would hold her accountable.

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The Silencing



Photo by Kristina Flour on Unsplash

Meera to Ananya (in a private instruction):

"Don't engage with him anymore. He's negative. He's just a critic. I've handled it."

Full Picture:

Arjun had given hours of research. He had shared frameworks. He had offered solutions. He had done all of this not for himself, but because he believed in the mission—if the platform grows, NGOs benefit.

What she could have said: *"I appreciate his feedback. Let's engage constructively and see if there's something we can learn."*

Instead, she said: *"Don't engage with him anymore."*

This was the final insult. Not just ignoring him—actively shutting him out. Wanting him gone. Wanting him silent. Wanting him invisible.

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The Rosy Corporate Language



Photo by Samuel Field on Unsplash

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Ananya watched Meera’s intervention and was impressed. She saw:

- “Strategic alignment”
- “Protecting the ecosystem”
- “Ensuring the integrity of the creator experience”
- “Our vision for the future”

She thought: *“This is how leaders speak. This is how they handle difficult people. This is how you maintain authority.”*

What she didn’t see was the cruelty beneath the words.

What Meera Said	What She Meant
"We value all feedback"	"We'll ignore what we don't like"
"This is a leadership matter"	"I'm going to silence him"
"We protect our ecosystem"	"We protect our ego"
"Strategic alignment"	"Don't question us"
"Ensuring integrity"	"We're right, you're wrong"

The Gen Z innocence.

Ananya believed the language. She believed Meera was a leader who cared. She believed the “problem” was being handled.

She had no idea that the creator who had asked those questions had just been silenced.

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Part Four: The Contribution



Photo by Vlad Hilitanu on Unsplash

What Arjun Actually Gave

Arjun didn't just create content. He gave strategic analysis, product feedback, and research insights—the kind that consultants charge thousands of dollars for.

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What He Gave	Why It Was Valuable
Analysis of platform failures (Koo, Byju's, PicSee)	Identified structural flaws
Research on user psychology (Ebbinghaus, Lemke, Caldini)	Grounded in evidence
Frameworks for listener acquisition	Strategic thinking
Insights on retention strategies	Product expertise
Engagement with technical team	Deep involvement
Detailed UX feedback	Practical improvement

He gave this despite having CFS—every hour he spent was a sacrifice of his limited energy.

He gave this despite being unemployed—every contribution was a gamble that it would help him rebuild his career.

He gave this despite knowing he might never get credit—because he believed in the mission.

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His Engagement with the Technical Team

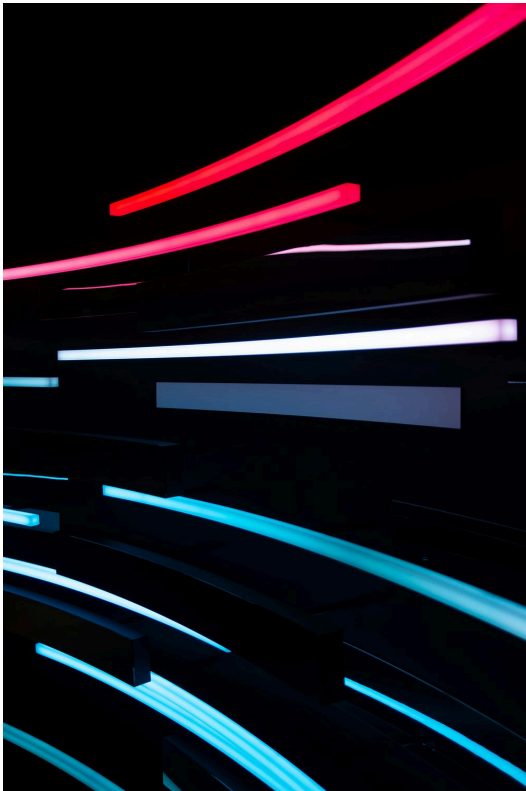


Photo by Maximalfocus on Unsplash

Arjun didn't just give feedback from the outside. He actively engaged with the technical team, providing:

- Detailed feedback on platform architecture
- User experience suggestions
- Product roadmap insights
- Practical recommendations for improvement

He was not a passive user. He was an active contributor who cared about the platform's success.

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Part Five: The Tragedy of the Reference



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The Architect Who Couldn't Speak



Photo by Nick Fewings on Unsplash

The Architect was a technology lead at VoxSphere. He had worked closely with Arjun on multiple occasions. He knew Arjun's work. He knew Arjun's technical contributions. He knew the value of the feedback Arjun had provided to the engineering team.

And yet, when Arjun asked for a reference—a simple acknowledgment—he stayed silent.

What The Architect Could Have Done	What He Did
Given a telephone reference	Stayed silent
Acknowledged Arjun's technical contribution	Ignored his request
Closed the issue with a simple word	Chose not to
Been human	Been silent

“The architect didn't have any rights. But she could have given a telephone reference that she would recommend him though we didn't work in papers, his feedback made sense for us stripping his technical contribution.”

This is the tragedy.

The Architect likely wanted to help. He likely knew Arjun's contribution was valuable. He likely felt the injustice. But he couldn't speak. Because he didn't have the power to represent the organization externally.

“Dear architect don’t come here the leadership could have checked with architect if needed they can’t give ref without leadership approval.”

This is the system.

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What He Could Say	What He Was Allowed to Say
"His feedback made sense to us"	Nothing
"His technical contributions were real"	Silence
"I can vouch for his work"	No authority
"He deserves acknowledgment"	No permission

This is the nature of corporate hierarchy. The people who know the truth often don't have the authority to speak it.

The Architect wasn't a villain. He was a bystander caught in a system that silences its own people.

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The Striping of Technical Contribution



Photo by Kelly Sikkema on Unsplash

Arjun’s technical contributions were real. He had provided detailed feedback on:

- Platform architecture
- User experience flow
- Product roadmap priorities
- Technical pain points

These were not just opinions. These were insights from someone who understood the platform deeply.

“His feedback made sense for us stripping his technical contribution.”

But when it came time to acknowledge him—to give him a reference, a recommendation, a simple “yes, he contributed”—the Architect couldn’t speak. Not because he didn’t want to. Because he wasn’t authorized to.

What They Took	What They Gave
His technical insights	Nothing
His strategic thinking	Nothing
His time and energy	Nothing
His trust	Betrayal

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Part Six: The NGO Connection



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The NGO Arjun Knew

Arjun had worked with NGOs before—not as a volunteer, but as a feedback giver. He had contributed his ideas, his insights, and his time. Often without credit. Often without recognition.

But they had something VoxSphere lacked.

What NGOs Gave Him	What VoxSphere Gave Him
A user ID and login	Silence
Access to grassroots communities	A closed door
Ethics to reply when he asked	Humiliation
Recognition of his ideas	Dismissal

“They got me through my tweets. They were reading my suggestions on ideas to keep girl children in school.”

This was before AI was born. This was before platforms. This was before metrics became the only thing that mattered. They were reading his suggestions—not because they had to, but because they believed in the mission.

“The motto of hearing is not just metrics. It’s the attempt to save each soul that we are missing in crisis.”

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The NGO Model vs. The Platform Model



Photo by Kseniia Samoylenko on Unsplash

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NGO Leadership	Platform Leadership
Saves lives	Saves metrics
Listens to voices	Counts voices
Acts on feedback	Silos feedback
Values contribution	Values compliance
Gives freely	Extracts without giving back
Believes in mission	Believes in growth
Empowers people	Silences people

“Even today, many NGOs are run by leadership and philanthropists. They could build better turnover for their knowledge. Still, they choose to give things for free—because the motto was to save life.”

The platform had no motto. Only metrics.

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The Platform’s NGO Partnership



Photo by Erik Mclean on Unsplash

VoxSphere had a partnership with an NGO. The details were not always clear, but Arjun knew that the platform’s success would

directly benefit the NGO's work. If the platform grew, the NGO would receive more resources, more visibility, and more impact.

This is why Arjun kept giving—even when everything told him to stop. Because his contribution wasn't just to VoxSphere. It was to the people the NGO served.

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What He Gave	Who It Was For
His research	The NGO's mission
His frameworks	The community's growth
His insights	The people they served
His effort	The greater good

“Only reason if it grows, many NGOs get benefits. Keeping my ego, humility aside.”

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The Gift That Wasn't Earned



Photo by Alex Shute on Unsplash

Arjun learned his boundaries the hard way. He was humiliated. He was dismissed. He was silenced. He was told his contributions were “nothing special.” He was instructed to be ignored.

And still, he gave.

Why?

Not because they deserved it.
Not because he expected credit.
Not because he was naive.

Because the platform was tied to an NGO. Because if the platform grew, people who needed help would get it.

“It’s their product, their choice. In the worst case, if it gets implemented, the platform may grow.”

This was the detachment. The clarity. The maturity.

He gave it freely, without attachment to the outcome.

Not because he believed in them. Because he believed in the mission.

Not because he expected anything in return. Because he could still think of others.

Even in his lowest moment. Even without a title. Even when no one was watching.

What He Had	What He Gave
Chronic Fatigue Syndrome	Hours he couldn't afford to lose
Unemployment	Energy he needed for survival
Humiliation	His dignity
Silence	His voice
Rejection	His hope
Nothing	Everything

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Part Seven: The HSP and the Corporate World

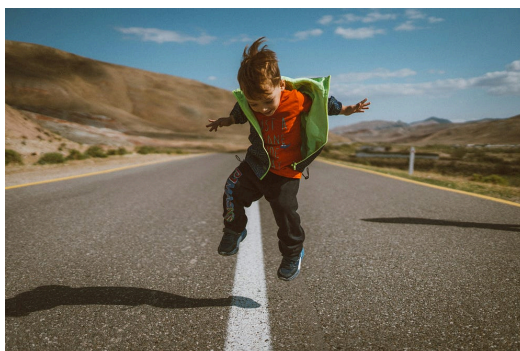


Photo by Alvin Mahmudov on Unsplash

The Boundary Difficulty

Arjun was an HSP—Highly Sensitive Person. This meant he:

- Felt everything deeper
- Noticed subtleties others missed
- Was easily overwhelmed
- Needed recovery time
- Absorbed others' emotions
- Struggled with boundaries

“Being HSP boundary difficult.”

He had learned to trust from his NGO experience. He had earned the trust of NGO leaders by showing up, contributing, and caring. They had earned his trust by listening, acknowledging, and respecting him.

But he didn't realize that corporate spaces, especially hustling startups are different.

NGO World	Corporate World
Trust is earned	Trust is exploited
Vulnerability is strength	Vulnerability is weakness
Contribution is valued	Contribution is extracted
People shed masks	People wear masks
Help is given freely	Help is transactional
Systems empower	Systems silence

“Join my team means free labour with no certificate.”

This was the harsh reality. In the corporate world, “join my team” often meant: *“Give me your work. Give me your ideas. Give me your energy. And I'll give you nothing in return.”*

Arjun didn't realize this until it was too late.

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The Mask That Sheds



Photo by Ahmed Zayan on Unsplash

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“People shed their mask when you show vulnerability or seek help.”

This was the hardest lesson.

In his vulnerable moments—when he was honest about his CAS, his CFS, his unemployment, his need for a reference—Meera showed her true self.

When He Showed Vulnerability	Her Response
CAS	"Monotone"
CFS	Ignored
Unemployment	"Do I know you?"
Need for reference	"Nothing special"
Trust	Humiliation

The mask came off.

And what Arjun saw underneath was not a leader. Not a partner. Not a human being.

Someone who saw his vulnerability as an opportunity to exploit.

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The Trust That Was Betrayed



Photo by Vitaly Gariev on Unsplash

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Where He Learned Trust	Where It Was Betrayed
NGO leaders who listened	Meera who humiliated
Leaders who acknowledged	Meera who dismissed
Leaders who gave freely	Meera who extracted
Leaders who cared	Meera who was indifferent

“He earned the trust of NGO, not realizing corporate are different.”

This was the tragedy. He had learned that trust was a two-way street —that if you gave, you would receive. That if you contributed, you would be valued. That if you showed up, you would be seen.

He had learned the wrong lesson.

Because in the corporate world, trust is often a one-way street. Give. Give. Give. And when you need something in return, you’re told: “Do I know you? Have you worked for me?”

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Part Eight: The Research



Photo by UX Indonesia on Unsplash

What Arjun Discovered

Despite the humiliation, Arjun kept learning. He dove deep. He read books. He studied research. He analyzed platform failures. He looked at what worked on platforms like StoryMirror, YouTube, and Instagram.

Here's what he found.

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1. Build for Listeners, Not Creators

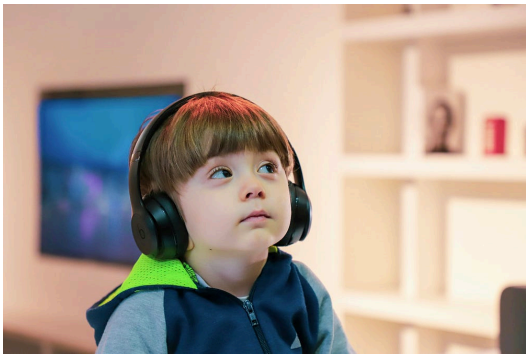


Photo by Alireza Attari on Unsplash

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If You Build For Creators	You Get	But You Need
Creators	Supply	Demand
Creators	Content	Listeners
Creators	Competition	Community

If everyone creates and no one listens, you don't have a community.
You have a room full of people talking to themselves.

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2. Friends and Family Are Not an Audience



Photo by Mike Scheid on Unsplash

They listen out of goodwill, not genuine interest. They get fatigued.
They are not real fans.

You can't build a platform on goodwill. You need real listeners.

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3. Creators Are Not Your Marketers



Photo by Markus Spiske on Unsplash

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What YouTube Offers	What New Platforms Offer
2+ billion active users	Zero built-in audience
Proven revenue sharing	Unproven, declining pay
Global discovery engine	No discovery

“If creators knew retention art, they can create in YouTube.”

“Bring people” isn’t a strategy. It’s a hope dressed as a plan.

. . .

4. Ego Destroys Platforms



Photo by Joel Lee on Unsplash

Unacademy’s CEO: “Byju failed because he didn’t listen to anyone. He put himself on a pedestal and stopped listening.”

Ego-Driven Leadership	The Result
"I know what's best"	Misses market signals
"Don't question me"	Loses honest feedback
"Creators should be grateful"	Loses creators

“Founder ego doesn’t mean power—you are about to crash.”

. . .

5. Treat Creators as Partners (Not Just in words, but in Action), Not Resources

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Photo by charlesdeluvio on Unsplash

When Creators Are Treated As	The Result
Vendors	Short-term engagement
Products	They feel exploited
Partners	Long-term retention

“72% of creators prefer long-term partnerships.”

* * *

6. The Bias Comes from Us



Photo by Jr Korpa on Unsplash

“We often blame AI and algorithms for being biased. But the bias comes from us—humans.”

AI isn't biased by itself. It learns from us. It mirrors us. It amplifies us.

The Algorithm Reflects	The Human Decision
Patterns of exclusion	Who we choose to see
Metrics of success	What we choose to value
Gaps in representation	Who we choose to ignore

The data was there. They just didn't want to see it.



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The Unseen Gender Divide

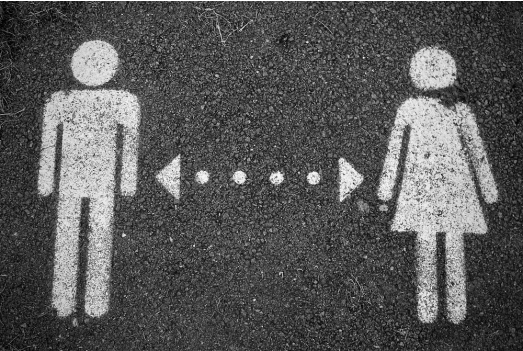


Photo by Pea on Unsplash

The Career Gap Question



Photo by Katja Ano on Unsplash

“Many companies have specific policies welcoming educated women. Where are the policies for the dropout girl—still competent in the corporate world?”

This is the question that nobody asks.

Who Gets Welcomed Back	Who Gets Filtered Out
Educated women with career breaks	Dropout girls with competence
Women returning from maternity	Caregivers who aren't women
Those with formal credentials	Those with lived experience
Women with degrees	Women with skills

Companies have returnship programs for women with career breaks. They have structured programs for professionals re-entering after maternity. They offer flexible work policies and paid leave extensions.

But where are the policies for the dropout girl who is still competent?

Where is the caregiver when they are not a woman?

“Gender equality is not about making other genders invisible in the crowd.”

“I am not against women empowerment. I just say: include all.”

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The Caregiver Question



Photo by Rod Long on Unsplash

“Where are the human rights considered here?”

Who Gets Support	Who Gets Overlooked
Women caregivers	Male caregivers
Primary caregivers	Secondary caregivers
Traditional families	All family types
Maternity leave recipients	Paternity leave recipients

“Fewer than 20% of companies provide secondary-caregiver leave.”

“Men fear career repercussions and rarely take caregiving leave.”

“Caregivers are supported, not penalized.”

This is what inclusion actually looks like. Not just checking a box.
Not just celebrating one group. Including everyone.

. . .

The Inclusion Question



Photo by Jon Tyson on Unsplash

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“Gender equality is not about making other genders invisible in the crowd.”

This is the leadership test.

What Companies Do	What They Should Do
Celebrate women returning to work	Create pathways for all caregivers
Offer maternity leave	Offer equal paternity leave
Welcome educated women back	Welcome dropouts with competence
Focus on one gender	Include all genders
Check boxes	Build systems

“I am not against women empowerment. I just say: include all.”

“Where are the human rights considered here?”

On Leadership & Strategy

“People stay when they grow. It’s not about perks or pay; it’s about whether they feel they’re becoming better versions of themselves here.”—Anand Mahindra, Chairman, Mahindra Group

“Any fool can buy talent; only real leaders develop it.”—Anonymous business proverb

“Talent is not for keeps; it’s for rent. The more we think about it like that, the more we will be different as leaders.”—D. Shivakumar, Corporate Leader

“If you can develop leaders internally, you’re better off.”—Anand Mahindra



On Talent Retention & Growth

“Sometimes your best people can be those homegrown, passionate, loyal stayers who have the company’s DNA programmed into their brains.”—Auntie B, SmartCompany

“A good leader gives the talent a tailwind, not a headwind. Encourage them a lot more. Ask them to try a lot more things for you. That’s how they will truly achieve their potential.”—D. Shivakumar

“The idea of one person’s statue in the town square feels outdated. Legacy should be institutional—the values, not the person. The epitaph on my tombstone should say—‘He built a company in which people were the best that they could ever be.’”—Anand Mahindra



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On People, Managers & The Human Side

“Employees/People don’t leave their job/company/organization, they leave their boss.”—Marcus Buckingham and Curt Coffman, *First, Break All the Rules* (1999)

“The quality of the employees’ relationship with the person for whom they worked; their manager” is the most decisive factor in employee retention.—Gallup Organization study (1999)



On Inclusive Leadership & Diverse Voices

“I stand by my trans and non-binary people. It’s not enough to quietly support... You are seen, you are valued, and you are not alone.”—Paul Sesay, Inclusion Leader

“TGNC leaders’ adaptive meaning-making abilities may be foundational to their leadership skills.”—Academic Research on Transgender Leadership

“Trans people in leadership scored higher than men or women on Idealized Influence behaviors, but lower on attributions of followers, pointing to possible discrimination.”—Academic Study of Trans Leaders

“A nonbinary participant mentioned moderating their authentic gender expression to avoid jeopardizing political projects.”—Leadership Research

The Leadership Test



Photo by Antoine Dautry on Unsplash

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If you're a leader, ask yourself:

Question	Your Answer
Are your return-to-work programs open to all?	___
Are your caregiver policies gender-neutral?	___
Do you recognize competence over credentials?	___
Are you celebrating one group or including all?	___
Are you building systems that serve everyone?	___

Because if you're only celebrating one group, you're not inclusive.

You're just performing inclusion.

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Part Nine: The Decision

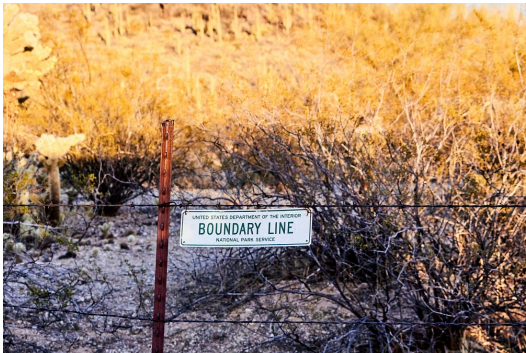


Photo by Erin Larson on Unsplash

Let Them Crash

“Let them crash.”

What He Gave	What It Cost Him
His time	Hours he'll never get back
His effort	Energy he couldn't afford to lose
His research	Mental exhaustion
His insights	Vulnerability
His hope	Emotional investment

Not out of anger. Not out of spite. Out of exhaustion. Out of self-preservation.

“I have CFS. I don’t have energy to waste on people who don’t value it.”

Instead of	He Chooses
Giving to them	Keeping for himself
Trying to help	Protecting his health
Seeking validation	Validating himself
Fighting for change	Letting go

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“They don’t want my help. They don’t want my voice. They don’t want my contribution.”

So I’ll stop giving it.

I’ll take my energy, my research, and my voice—and go somewhere they’re valued.

. . .

Part Ten: The Core Lessons



Photo by Quilia on Unsplash

On Leadership



Photo by Jehyun Sung on Unsplash

- 1. Leaders who can’t handle criticism aren’t leading—they’re managing their ego.
- 2. Honest questions are not attacks—they’re opportunities to learn.
- 3. Feedback is a gift. Leaders who can’t receive it will fail.
- 4. Ego destroys platforms faster than bad markets.
- 5. Targeting vulnerability isn’t leadership—it’s cruelty.
- 6. Listening is the first quality of a leader.
- 7. Corporate language can mask cruelty. The naive are easily impressed.

8. Young professionals are not enemies—they are learning. The system fails them too.

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On Platforms



Photo by Shubham Dhage on Unsplash

1. Build for listeners, not creators.
2. Treat creators as partners, not resources.
3. You can't outsource audience building to creators.
4. Community is built, not bought.
5. Inclusion isn't optional—it's essential.
6. Metrics are not the mission.

On Self-Preservation

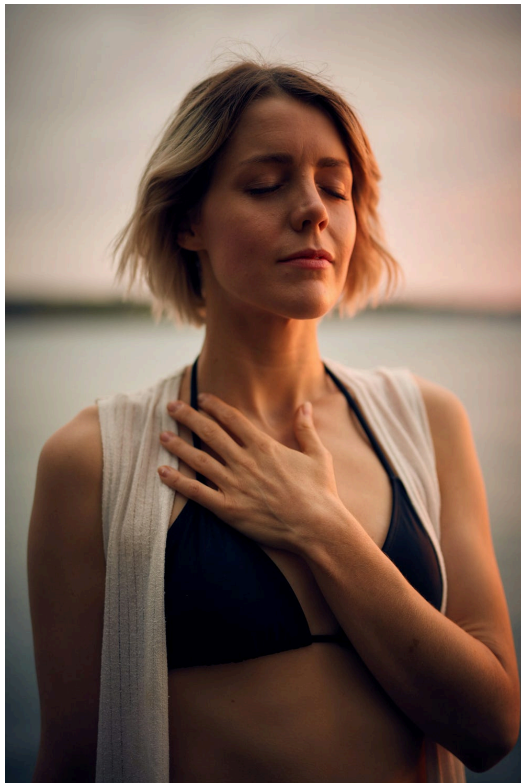


Photo by Darius Bashar on Unsplash

1. Not every space deserves your energy.
2. Not every platform deserves your contributions.
3. Not every leader deserves your trust.
4. Letting go is not giving up—it's choosing yourself.
5. Your health matters more than their success.

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On Inclusion



Photo by Hannah Busing on Unsplash

1. We need a world where everyone gets treated equally—not neurotypical, neurodivergent, and other people as well.
2. Gender equality is not about making other genders invisible in the crowd.
3. Caregivers deserve support—regardless of gender.
4. Human rights apply to everyone.
5. Empathy is a rare commodity. And it's the most valuable one.

Epilogue: The World We Should Build



Photo by Tim Mossholder on Unsplash

"In a world of diverse people, the person is an empath and HSP. It hits differently for them."

This is not a weakness. This is a strength.

Empaths feel more. HSPs notice more. They care more. They give more.

And they are punished for it.

Not because they are wrong. But because leadership is blind.

“We need a world where everyone gets treated equally—not neurotypical, neurodivergent, and other people as well.”

This is the world we should be building.

Not for metrics. Not for growth. Not for ego.

For people.

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The Final Truth



Photo by Marvin Meyer on Unsplash

“To the community manager, why is your community creator escalating to me? I'll take care from here. Community manager impressed with rosy corporate language the gen z innocence. The problem solved leadership visibility at the end.”

This is the tragedy of the system.

Ananya saw leadership. She saw authority. She saw the “problem” being handled.

What she didn't see was the cruelty. The silencing. The erasure of a human being who had given everything.

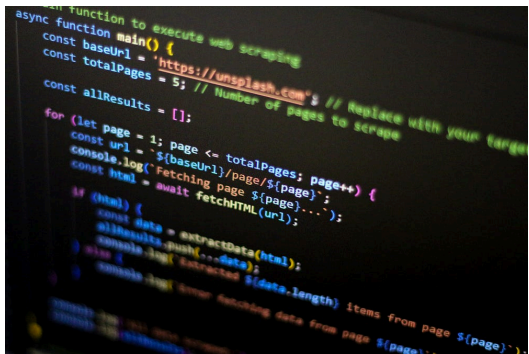


Photo by Glen Carrie on Unsplash

“Dear architect don't come here the leadership could have checked with architect if needed they can't give ref without leadership approval the hierarchy.”

This is the system's betrayal.

The Architect couldn't speak. Ananya was deceived. Arjun was silenced.

And Meera was celebrated as a leader.

This is the tragedy of our times.

“The architect didn’t have any rights. But Meera, could have given a telephone reference that she would recommend him though we didn’t work in papers, his feedback made sense for us stripping his technical contribution.”

This is the tragedy.

The Architect could have simply said “no.”

Instead, he chose silence.

She chose cruelty.

They chose to let him fall.

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Photo by Susan Wilkinson on Unsplash

But here's the thing; he didn't fall.

He learned. He grew. He kept going.

And he wrote this story.

Not for revenge. Not for recognition. For understanding.

For the next person who will be told they don't matter.

For the next creator who will be humiliated for asking questions.

For the next empath who will be told they feel too much.

For the next patient who will be told their disability is an excuse.

For the next caregiver who will be told they don't count.

For the next unemployed person who will be told they have no value.

For the next person without a title who will be told they have no right to speak.

For the next community manager who will be fooled by rosy corporate language.

For the next architect who will be silenced by hierarchy.
For the next young professional who will be used as a shield.
You matter. Your voice matters. Your contributions matter.
And no amount of silence can erase that.

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A Message to Leaders

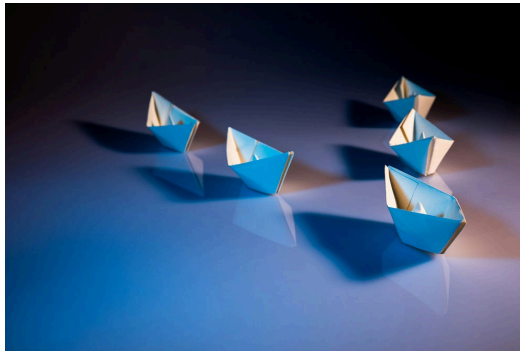


Photo by KOBU Agency on Unsplash

If you're a leader reading this:

Are you inclusive, or do you just say you are?

Are you listening, or are you just waiting to speak?

Are you protecting your ego, or are you building something that lasts?

Are you seeing the people behind the contributions?

Are you treating creators as partners, not resources?

Are you creating a space where everyone feels seen, heard, and valued?

Or are you just using corporate language to mask your cruelty?

Because if you're not—you're not a leader.

You're just someone with power.

You have the title. Arjun had the heart.

You had the power. Arjun had the purpose.

You built a platform. Arjun built a legacy.

Ask yourself: which one are you building?

“Any relationship—personal or professional—is built on human psychology. Leadership evolved from psychology, not from degrees. Certificates and titles don't make great people; they just make paper holders.

Big organizations and some startups with empathetic leaders are finally realizing they need problem solvers, not a bunch of certificate holders.

This story is an example of user churn, but on a bigger scale—it's why employees quit. How can i lead without influence? Is my pay fair

to their skills? How can we shield them during their low moments? A leader should ask themself.

We talk about empathy, but where is it when it matters?

Employee retention strategy needs to be the vision—not paying an outsider a hefty package while the dedicated, home-grown employee gets a ‘C’ grade in the name of fitting the curve.

We say, ‘People leave bad managers, not companies.’ But what action did we take to retain those employees? promoting bad manager behaviour!

That is the question.”

— Arjun, *The Architect of Silence*

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#Leadership #Empathy #HSP #Inclusion #Neurodiversity
#PlatformStrategy #CreatorEconomy #Humanity #Caregiving
#DisabilityAwareness #ChronicIllness #CFS #CAS #Unemployment #NGO
#SocialImpact #CorporateCulture #GenZ

. . .

If this story resonates with you, share it. Not for recognition. But because someone else might need to hear it.